Reading notes: systems thinking

A system is a set of elements connected so that together they produce a pattern of behavior over time. The interesting part is rarely the elements; it is the interconnections and the purpose.

Stocks and flows: a stock is anything that accumulates (water in a bathtub, money in savings, trust in a team). Flows change stocks. Stocks change slowly, which creates delays, buffers and the feeling that nothing is happening until suddenly everything is.

Feedback loops

Balancing loops push a stock toward a goal (a thermostat). Reinforcing loops amplify change in either direction (compound interest, or a team losing people and overloading the rest).

Leverage points: changing parameters (budgets, quotas) is the weakest lever. Changing feedback structure, information flows, or the goal of the system is much stronger.

Personal takeaway: my overflowing inbox is a stock with an inflow I don't control. Reduce the inflow (unsubscribe, filters) instead of only trying to increase the outflow.